High Schools Should Start Later, but Districts Must Plan for the Bus Bill

[needs: student name] [needs: course and instructor, English 102] [needs: due date]

High schools should start later in the morning. The evidence in the studies reviewed here shows a clear benefit in attendance, no sign of harm to test scores, and one real cost, transportation. That cost is large enough that a district should budget for it before it moves the first bell. It is not large enough to block the change.

The strongest evidence concerns attendance. Rivera (2021) followed 4,200 students in one district after the first bell moved 45 minutes later. Attendance rose from 91.4% to 93.5%, a gain of 2.1 percentage points. A student who is not in the building cannot learn from the lesson, so a rise in attendance is a rise in the time students have with their teachers. The gain was not spread evenly. Grades 11 and 12 improved by 3.0 percentage points (Rivera, 2021). Older students gained the most.

Critics may reply that a later start should show up in grades, and the evidence here does not show that it does. Chen and Okoye (2022) studied 3,900 students and found that test scores did not change significantly in the first year after a later start. The mean difference was 0.4 points on a 100-point scale ($p = .62$). This result deserves a fair reading. It does not show that later starts hurt learning, since scores held steady while attendance rose. It also does not show that scores will stay flat. The authors say longer follow-up is needed (Chen & Okoye, 2022). A district that adopts a later start should therefore track scores for several years and report them to families.

The cost side is the hardest part of the case for supporters. Brooks (2023) sampled 15 districts that moved to later starts. Eleven of them needed an extra bus tier, and transportation

costs rose by an average of 6.2% of the transportation budget. Most districts in that sample paid more, and a plan that ignores this will fail in its first budget cycle.

References

Brooks, D. (2023). Bus schedules under later bell times. *Fictional Transportation Review, 9*(2), 101-117.

Chen, L., & Okoye, A. (2022). Start times and test scores in one district. *Journal of Fictional Education, 14*(1), 12-30.

Rivera, M. (2021). Later start times and attendance. *Journal of Fictional Education, 12*(3), 44-58.